Gerald the Life-sized Talking Spork
by Spill Major

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Gerald the Life-sized Talking Spork.

Hello, I'm Gerald, the life-sized talking spork. You have no idea how many pills I have to take just to say that without crying. My life is a sick joke. Please, please help me.

Who wants to learn about sporks today? Wow, there's a lot of you. Well you're all freaking crazy. But here it goes anyhow. (*He drinks from a flask – clearly has a special pocket in his costume just for this. Then, he is suddenly animated.*) I'm here today to tell you about the amazing history of me, the spork! The spork was first invented around 3000 B.C., but of course that's because someone carved one out of a stone on accident. Not knowing what to do with it, scientists speculate that cavemen probably tried it out as a comb, a pubic comb, a tongue depressor, and a nose piercing before finally settling on using it gouge out other cavemen's eyes. And it is from those days that we get our current use of the spork – because once the cavemen gouged out the eye, they realized could then use the spork to devour it! (*He is handed a card from offstage*) What's this? Gerald, read what's on the cards or we will take you off the health plan. Well folks, I guess we know who's the boss around here: that's right, Mr. Codine Co-pay! So, because I can't take having my friends at the rehab center see me in this pathetic costume, here's the real history of… The Spork.

The modern day spork actually started with the chopstick. No, I'm not saying they had sporks back in the ancient Orient; they were much too smart for that. But then, of course, an American had to come along – in this case, General… H … X… niner… should know his full name… McArthur, who was in charge of occupied Japan after World War II. As an American who naturally feared the presence of any culture or tradition, the good General banned all chopsticks, decreeing them uncivilized. However, the common "fork" was seen as a dangerous weapon of insurrection, so the Japanese could not be switched over to traditional, deadly American silverware. Since my two-year-old spends the 3 hours per week I have with him jabbing me with objects like chopsticks, forks, and desk lamps, I can't say I blame ol' Mickey A.

Well, as you no doubt guessed cause you just couldn't wait for the me to tell you, you impatient people you, the compromise the army reached between eating utensil and deadly weapon was the spork. It was tough enough to dig into teriyaki chicken, but not so tough as to be used to repel an occupying force of several million troops. I know, I know, it's a fine line, like the line between social drinking and pathetic self-loathing alcoholism (*drinks*). My probation officer says drinking straight from the handle of rum in the donut store at 9am counts as the latter, but I say, hey, I was just being *social* with that nice donut-serving lady. Although, I guess when the manager asked me to leave and I tried to drown him in the vat of icing, that wasn't so social. Oh well, you live and you learn. Like us, right? I'm learning about how terrible life can be, and you're learning about sporks.

Here's something that combines both. When researching this little spiel, the nice people here at Billinson's Plastic Works found out that the largest spork on record belongs to the U.S. Navy, who use a metal version almost six feet long for preparing food. Then they saw me. In my costume. And they realized that I, in fact, am the largest spork on record. Yes

friends, that's right, you're witnessing history. Spork history. Right here in front of you. Isn't that great?

I'll give you a hint. No. It's not great. It's awful. Sometimes, I look in the mirror. I look real deep, past the spork, past the bags in my eyes, the sores on my lips. I look deep in that mirror and I see myself, a young boy, 11 or 12. Sure, I've used sporks in restaurants. Maybe I even enjoyed it. But my life is free, it's open, it's not bound by any utensils. I think about that boy, with his precious freedom, and I weep. Not just for me, but for all of humanity. Ok, well, really, I just weep for me.

You're not interested in me. You're here at the Billinson Sporkworks because you're interested in sporks. Obviously, there's something wrong with you. But you've learned a lot about them. I hope you care, I sure don't. I care about paying my ex-wife to support her new boyfriend… they can afford real forks and spoons, I assure you.

Now, because this is America and you can't learn anything without also being persuaded to buy something, I will tell you a little bit about the history of our company, Billinson Sporkworks.

Billinson started off as Billinson Badgers. For some reason, during the Great Depression, the federal government paid Bill Boxer Sr. an awful lot of money to farm badgers on the great plains. For what purpose the badgers would be used, it was never clear, but it was judged somehow useful to have a stockpile of badgers on hand. They just sold them right back to the government, Lord knows what they did with them. This continued until one fateful night in the late 40's, if you consider the destiny of a spork factory to be anything that fate remotely cares about.

On that night, Bill Sr. made a desperate run to the outhouse right as a big Plains-country storm was rolling in. He wanted to take care of business before the lightning started. Ol' Bill mistimed it, you see, and he was trapped in the outhouse as rains blew and thunder bellowed around him. He underestimated the storm, though, and there was a flash flood. He worried about the badgers, though they seemed to have a place to hide during the storm. Bill was about to find out where.

He heard it first. A rumbling below him. Then, the outhouse started to shake, the pipes clanking and whining. A huge jolt shot Bill off the can, and just in time. The toilet literally lifted off the ground and shot out of the ground on a column of sewage and flood water. That wasn't all, though. Then the badgers emerged. Hundreds. Bill was in the storm now, watching in amazement as his entire stock of badgers were flooded out from their storm shelter, his septic system. Bill could only assume that they had created great caves around the original tank; that would explain why he had never needed to have it drained.

This thought lasted only a second. The next second, Bill was fleeing a horde of angry, smelly badgers. You can't make this up.

Then, wouldn't you know it, Lightning struck one of the hordes. The sewage protected the badgers, but the outer layer of sludge on them was burning. A mass of flaming, poop-

covered badgers pursued Bill back to the house. Wilma, his wife, was waiting at the door, and thank goodness. She had the garden hose going full blast, nearly drained the whole reservoir. But it kept the badgers at bay until Bill Jr. could marshal them with a tractor towards the barn. Bill Sr. watched with wild eyes, panting and cursing.

The next day, Bill saw a story about sporks in a newspaper. “That’s what we’re making from now on, son. Sporks.” And now you have me, up here, the saddest utensil alive.

Sometimes, I look in the mirror, when I have my costume on, and I don’t entirely hate myself. There’s something beautiful in the spork, or at least in its simplicity. Two ideas, turned into one. That’s a rare thing in a world that keeps getting more complicated. It gives you hope, for a minute, that people might figure something out. But then the next minute, I’m still in the spork costume.

I know a lot of you will go away from this night and remember the sporks. As chief representative of sporkkind, allow me to say this: please reconsider that decision. Please, please reconsider. Forget us. Forget me. Don’t speak of this night to anyone… ever. If you do, I’ll slash your tires. Hard as that is to do with a spork, but, I’ve got a pretty big spork.. Oh God, please, why won’t you reconsider?

No? Well, Fork you. Fork you *and* spoon you.

And look at this… (*brings on baby doll in spork costume*) We don’t even know who the father is. Hell, we don’t even know if it’s a father he’s missing. Who can tell?

They’re giving me that look now, so I guess I’m done. I’ll see you at the end of the show. (*walking off*) If I don’t set it on fire first. (*looks at someone offstage*). I know, I know, if I set it on fire I won’t get my paycheck, and then my ex-wife gets my house, I understand. You’re a real pain in the ass. Or stem. Whatever I have. (*back out*) Buenas Noches, losers.